Homeowner Roof Inspection Checklist

Catch most roof problems in about 45 minutes, without walking the roof.

- Ground, attic and interior checks in the order a pro walks a roof
- Code references to the 2018 IRC, as adopted in Indiana
- Your rights when storm chasers knock (IC 24-5-11)

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You can catch 90% of roof problems in about 45 minutes without ever stepping on the roof. Work from the ground, then the attic, then inside the house. Tick each box as you go. If anything in section 12, "When to call a pro," fits your roof, stop guessing and get a licensed roofer or inspector out there.

I've been doing construction and roof inspections for 20+ years. This is the same order I walk a roof in, written so a homeowner can do it safely. Code references are to the 2018 International Residential Code (IRC), which is what Indiana's residential code is built on (see the code section at the end).

1. Safety first

Most homeowners have no business walking a roof. Binoculars, a phone zoom, or a drone will show you almost everything you need.

- [ ] Stay off any roof that is wet, frosty, mossy, or steeper than about 6 in 12 (6 inches of rise per foot)
- [ ] Never walk on slate, clay, or concrete tile. You will break it
- [ ] If you use a ladder, set it on firm level ground at about a 4 to 1 angle (1 foot out for every 4 feet up)
- [ ] Ladder extends at least 3 feet past the roof edge (the OSHA standard for workers, 29 CFR 1926.1053(b)(1), is a good rule for you too)
- [ ] Keep ladders and tools at least 10 feet from overhead power lines
- [ ] Someone else is home and knows you're on the ladder
- [ ] In the attic, step only on joists or trusses, never between them. You'll go through the ceiling

2. Ground-level walkaround

Walk all four sides. Then cross the street and look at the whole roof line.

- [ ] Ridge line is straight. A sag or dip points to rafter, truss, or decking trouble
- [ ] Roof plane looks flat, not wavy or bellied between rafters
- [ ] No missing shingles or bare spots after wind
- [ ] No shingles, granules, or pieces of flashing lying in the yard or on the driveway
- [ ] Gutters hang straight and are attached tight to the fascia
- [ ] Fascia and soffit boards aren't rotted, stained, or pulling away
- [ ] Downspouts discharge away from the foundation, not right at it
- [ ] Exterior walls under roof-to-wall corners show no streaking, rot, or peeling paint (missing kickout flashing, see section 5)
- [ ] Trees aren't touching or hanging over the roof

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3. Attic check

The attic tells you more than the top of the roof does. Go up on a bright day with a good flashlight. In winter, go on a cold morning.

- [ ] With the light off, no daylight shows through the roof deck except at ridge and soffit vents
- [ ] No water stains, drip marks, or dark rings on the underside of the decking or rafters
- [ ] No black or fuzzy mold on the decking, especially on the north side
- [ ] Insulation is dry and not matted or stained
- [ ] Sheathing isn't delaminating, soft, or sagging between rafters
- [ ] Nail tips coming through the deck aren't rusty or wearing frost (frost on nails in winter means warm moist air is getting up there)
- [ ] Soffit vents aren't buried in insulation. Baffles keep at least a 1 inch air space between insulation and the roof deck (R806.3)
- [ ] Bath fans and kitchen hoods vent all the way outside, not into the attic (IRC M1501.1 says exhaust can't discharge into an attic, soffit, ridge vent, or crawl space)

4. Shingle condition

Asphalt shingles are what most of us have. A 3-tab roof typically lasts 15 to 20 years. Architectural (dimensional) shingles usually go 20 to 30. Hail, poor ventilation, and bad nailing cut those numbers down fast.

- [ ] No missing or torn shingles
- [ ] No curling: edges turning up (cupping) or corners lifting with the middle down (clawing)
- [ ] No heavy granule loss. Bald black spots on shingles, or granules piling up in gutters and at downspouts
- [ ] No nail pops. A shingle bumped up in a little tent means a nail is backing out
- [ ] No exposed nail heads in the field of the roof
- [ ] No cracks or splits running across shingles
- [ ] No round dark bruises or dents after a hailstorm (check soft metals like vents and gutters for dents too)
- [ ] Shingle tabs are sealed down and not flapping

Black streaks are usually algae. That's mostly cosmetic and not a leak by itself.

What code expects when shingles go on: asphalt shingles need a slope of at least 2 in 12, and slopes from 2 in 12 up to 4 in 12 need double underlayment (R905.2.2). Each strip shingle needs at least 4 nails, or more if the manufacturer requires it (R905.2.6). Nails must go at least 3/4 inch into the deck or all the way through it (R905.2.5).

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5. Flashing

Most leaks I find are flashing, not shingles. Look anywhere the roof meets something else (R903.2.1).

Chimney

- [ ] Step flashing along the sides and counterflashing set into the mortar joints, not just caulked to the face of the brick
- [ ] No gaps, rust-through, or tar patches smeared over the joints (tar is a band-aid, not a repair)
- [ ] Mortar joints and the chimney crown aren't cracked or crumbling
- [ ] A chimney wider than 30 inches has a cricket (saddle) on the uphill side to split water around it (R903.2.2)

Walls and dormers

- [ ] Step flashing, one piece per shingle course, where the roof runs up a sidewall (R905.2.8.3)
- [ ] Siding sits above the roof surface, not jammed down into the shingles
- [ ] Kickout flashing at the bottom of every roof-to-wall line, turning water into the gutter instead of down the wall (R903.2.1)

Valleys

- [ ] Valley shingles or valley metal aren't worn, cracked, or loaded with debris (R905.2.8.2)
- [ ] No nails driven through the center of the valley

Vents, pipes, and skylights

- [ ] Rubber pipe boots aren't cracked or split (they often fail around 8 to 12 years, well before the shingles)
- [ ] Box vents, turbines, and ridge vents are tight with no lifted edges
- [ ] Skylight flashing is intact, with no stains on the interior well

6. Roof edges and drip edge

- [ ] Metal drip edge runs along every eave and rake edge (R905.2.8.5)
- [ ] Drip edge pieces overlap at least 2 inches, extend at least 1/4 inch below the sheathing, and go at least 2 inches back onto the deck (R905.2.8.5)
- [ ] Drip edge is nailed no more than 12 inches apart (R905.2.8.5)
- [ ] Underlayment laps over the drip edge at the eaves and under it at the rakes (R905.2.8.5)
- [ ] Shingles overhang the drip edge slightly so water drops into the gutter
- [ ] No rot on the first few feet of decking at the eave (look from the attic)

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7. Underlayment and ice barrier

You can't see underlayment on a finished roof, but you can ask for it in writing on any new roof. It's the backup layer that keeps water out when shingles fail.

- [ ] Contract lists the underlayment type and that it meets the code tables (R905.1.1)
- [ ] Contract lists ice barrier (ice and water shield) at the eaves if your area or the shingle maker requires it
- [ ] Ice barrier runs from the eave edge to at least 24 inches inside the exterior wall line (R905.1.2)
- [ ] You've had ice dams before? Then you want ice barrier, period, whatever the minimum says

Indiana note: Indiana amended the IRC county table (Table R301.2(1), amended by 675 IAC 14-4.4-5) so ice barrier is mandatory in 27 northern counties, including Allen, Elkhart, Lake, LaPorte, Porter, and St. Joseph. In the rest of the state, including Delaware County, the state fire and building safety office says it's still required when the shingle manufacturer's written installation instructions call for it. Most major shingle makers do, and skipping it can void the warranty. Ask your roofer to show you the manufacturer's instructions.

8. Attic ventilation

Bad ventilation cooks shingles from underneath in summer and causes frost, mold, and ice dams in winter.

- [ ] Attic has intake vents low (soffits) and exhaust vents high (ridge or upper vents) so air moves through every attic space (R806.1)
- [ ] Total net free vent area is at least 1/150 of the attic floor area, or 1/300 when 40% to 50% of it is in upper vents and the rest low (R806.2)
- [ ] At least 1 inch of air space between insulation and the roof deck at the vents (R806.3)
- [ ] Not mixing exhaust types on one roof (for example, a ridge vent plus box vents or a gable fan can short-circuit airflow)

Quick math: a 1,500 sq ft attic at 1/300 needs 5 sq ft (720 sq in) of net free area, about half high and half low. At 1/150 it needs 10 sq ft.

9. Decking soft spots

This one's for a pro or for you from the attic side only.

- [ ] No soft, spongy spots when a roofer walks the deck
- [ ] No sagging between rafters seen from the street or the attic
- [ ] No dark, rotted, or delaminated plywood or OSB from below, especially around chimneys, valleys, and pipe boots

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10. Signs of leaks inside the house

- [ ] No brown rings or bubbling paint on ceilings, especially top-floor ceilings and closet ceilings
- [ ] No stains around chimney chases, skylights, or exterior wall corners
- [ ] No musty smell in upstairs rooms or closets
- [ ] No peeling paint or swollen trim at the top of exterior walls
- [ ] Stains don't grow after a rain (mark the edge with a pencil and check again)

11. Repair or replace

What you found	Usually a repair	Usually a replacement
A few missing or torn shingles	Yes	
Leak at one chimney, wall, or pipe boot	Yes, reflash or replace the boot	
Granule loss or curling across most of the roof		Yes
Shingles past their expected life and failing in several spots		Yes
Soft or rotted decking in one small area	Yes, cut out and replace that section	
Widespread soft decking or sagging		Yes, plus structural repair
Hail damage across a full slope		Often, and it may be an insurance claim
Roof already has two layers of shingles		Tear-off required

Code decides one big question for you: a new layer can't go over the old one (a "recover") when the existing roof is water-soaked or too deteriorated to be a base, when it's slate, clay, cement, or asbestos-cement tile, or when it already has two or more layers (R908.3.1.1). In any of those cases it's a tear-off down to the deck.

12. When to call a pro

- [ ] Any active leak you can't trace
- [ ] Sagging ridge or roof plane
- [ ] Soft decking, or mold on more than a small patch of decking
- [ ] Hail or wind damage you may file an insurance claim for (get it documented before anything is torn off)
- [ ] Chimney flashing or crown problems
- [ ] Roof is steeper than you can safely stand on
- [ ] You're buying or selling the house

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13. Storm chasers: your rights in Indiana

After a hailstorm, door knockers show up fast. Indiana law gives you some protection on home improvement contracts.

- [ ] You can cancel a home improvement contract before midnight of the third business day after the later of (1) the day you both signed it, or (2) the day you get your insurance company's written final decision on whether the claim is covered (IC 24-5-11-10.6(c))
- [ ] The contractor has to give you that cancellation statement and a written Notice of Cancellation form before you sign (IC 24-5-11-10.6(b))
- [ ] If you cancel in writing, they must return your payments and deposits within 10 days, though they can bill the reasonable value of emergency work you okayed in writing first (IC 24-5-11-10.6(d) and (e))
- [ ] A contractor can't offer to pay or rebate your insurance deductible, or give you gifts, credits, or referral fees to get the job (IC 24-5-11-10.5(a))
- [ ] A contractor can't act as your public adjuster on the claim (IC 24-5-11-10.5(d))
- [ ] Problems with a contractor can be reported to the Indiana Attorney General's Consumer Protection Division

This is a summary of the statute text, not legal advice. For a real dispute, talk to an Indiana attorney.

14. Code references

Indiana's residential code is the 2020 Indiana Residential Code, 675 IAC 14-4.4, effective December 26, 2019. It adopts the 2018 IRC (first printing) with Indiana amendments. No newer residential code was in effect as of this guide's date. Cities and counties issue permits and may have local requirements, so check with your local building department.

Topic	2018 IRC section
Flashing locations, kickout flashing	R903.2.1
Chimney crickets and saddles	R903.2.2
Underlayment	R905.1.1
Ice barrier	R905.1.2
Asphalt shingle slope	R905.2.2
Shingle fasteners	R905.2.5
Shingle attachment (nails per strip)	R905.2.6
Valley flashing	R905.2.8.2
Sidewall step flashing	R905.2.8.3
Drip edge	R905.2.8.5
Reroofing, when a recover isn't allowed	R908.3.1.1

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Topic	2018 IRC section
Attic ventilation required	R806.1
Minimum vent area	R806.2
Insulation clearance at vents	R806.3
Exhaust can't discharge into the attic	M1501.1
Indiana ice barrier counties	Table R301.2(1), 675 IAC 14-4.4-5

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Sources

- Indiana Fire Prevention and Building Safety Commission rules
- Indiana Association of Building Officials, current code
- Indiana DHS ice and water shield update, 2020
- IC 24-5-11-10.5
- IC 24-5-11-10.6
- Gillette, WY 2018 IRC reroofing sheet
- East Point, GA 2018 IRC re-roof guide
- Firestone, CO reroof requirements, 2018 IRC

This checklist is general information for homeowners, not a substitute for a licensed roofer, home inspector or attorney. Codes and local amendments change, so confirm requirements with your local building department.

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